

85 on the other hand, UNESCO recognition, first, and designation as European Capital of Culture in 2019, then, tried to overturn this vision. The staging of memory: Matera European Capital of Culture 2019 The idea to apply for Matera as European Capital of Culture for 2019 was born in 2008 and it belonged to an association of citizens and, after alternating political and institutional events, took shape in 2014, when, on 17 October, the Minister for Cultural Heritage and Activities and Tourism Dario Franceschini, following the assessment of an international jury, proclaimed Matera European Capital of Culture for 2019. About a month before, the Fondazione Matera-Basilicata 2019 was established, with the aim of managing, monitoring and evaluating the entire process. The application file, drawn up by the Matera 2019 Committee, is based on five thematic strands, which find their *raison d'être* in the relationship with the past: Remote Future, Continuity and Ruptures, Utopias and Dystopias, Roots and Paths, Reflections and Connections. The five themes are the common thread along which the entire file is developed, as well as most of the initiatives financed and carried out by the Foundation during the year 2019. The “functional manipulation of memory”, and its staging, has played a decisive role and has certainly influenced the rhetoric of representation and communication linked to the city and its relationship with the past, especially with reference to the past-future dichotomy. The, then mayor of the city, Salvatore Adduce, wrote in the first pages of the file: “The unique experience of a community which, in the immediate post-war period, was able to face the terrible question of the uninhabitable nature of its beautiful city, allows us to tell the whole world that from a great emergency, such as that of the emptying of the Sassi, it is possible to ensure, through intelligent planning, new hospitality to an entire population. [...] The new challenge consists in proposing to the citizens to “regenerate” the city together, overcoming the distrust and fatalism that often characterize our territories. Matera and Basilicata want to announce to Europe that another South is possible, putting behind them the stereotypes of a Southern Italy bent on itself and in perennial waiting for assistance.”⁵ The objective, therefore, clearly stated by the two files, is to contribute to creating, on the part of the Matera community, but also on the part of the institutional powers, a new collective conscience, which reappropriates its own memory and makes it a source of pride. The tourism factor favours, and in some cases accelerates, this process of re-appropriation. Without going into the merits of what was, or could have been, such an opportunity, let us try to examine some examples of how the functional use of “memory” has contributed in many cases to overturning the hitherto stereotyped vision of a timeless reality, a symbol of archaism and backwardness as a reason for pride, contributing to defining, through the elaboration, construction, attribution and use of elements linked to the past and tradition, what Eugenio Imbriani, the Italian

5 Salvatore Adduce, *Matera città candidata capitale europea della cultura 2019 Dossier finale di candidatura* (Matera: Fondazione Matera-Basilicata 2019, 2008), 3-4.